

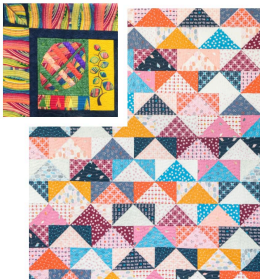
Session 3: The Difference Between Meaning and Significance

Key Takeaways

- Pay attention to the context and shape of the text to better understand the authors’ intended meaning.
- Prioritize questions of the text’s original meaning over questions of its significance for modern questions.

The Many Potential Contexts of the Adam and Eve Story

In our modern cultural setting, the Adam and Eve story has been made to speak to many topics that the biblical authors did not mean to address. We must be vigilant to make a distinction between asking what Genesis 2-5 means within the context of the TaNaK versus what it means for other areas of interest. The difference is one of intention. The biblical authors intended for the stories to address the main issues at work in the TaNaK, not our modern concerns. However, Genesis 2-5 may have significance for how we think about other topics in light of the biblical perspective, but we should not mistake this for the meaning of Genesis 2-5 in its native context.

Meaning		Significance		
Genesis 2-5	TaNaK	Introduction to Anthropology	A Primer on Gender Theory	A Theology of Original Sin
				

The Meaning Versus Significance of Genesis 2-5. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Reflection Question

What is the difference between meaning and significance when talking about studying the Bible?